The Shape of a Girl

By Joan MacLeod

BRADIE: **[Pg 29-30]** [It is second grade and] we are in love, we are all forever in love -- piles and piles of ponies. Little brushes for their tiny pink manes, their purple tails. We spend hours drawing them, me and Adrienne and Amber. We call ourselves by our new names in secret: [Adrienne is] Rainbow Rider, [Amber is] Lucky Lady, and [I am] Thunder. Sofie is the new girl in grade two. Her horse name is Gypsy. [But] Sofie doesn't just fall in love with horses; she gallops out to the playground for recess; she talks by doing whinnies and stomping her feet; she never cares about who sees.

ADRIENNE: Good little horsie.

BRADIE: We love Sofie the horse. We make tiny braids all over her head; we paint rainbows on her cheeks.

INTRODUCTION

For girls, childhood was once a time of carefree days of friendships and make believe. But times have changed and mean girl issues that never emerged until middle school are now becoming prevalent as early as 2nd grade.

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According to Erik Stangvik, a top executive at No Bully, one of America's top anti-bullying advocacy groups "Young girls, often operating under a 'pack mentality,' isolate and banish their targets from the tribe, making them feel as if they don't belong. They gossip and start rumors and call the other girls names. It's nothing short of psychological warfare.

*And whether you **are** the bully or part of the group who sees it happening and says nothing, you could be part of the bullying monster in . . .*

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BRADIE: **[Pg 30-31]** And then one day, one normal un-special day Adrienne comes to school and announces . . .

ADRIENNE: It's penalty day!

BRADIE: We don't know what penalty day is.

ADRIENNE: On penalty day one girl is chosen and everyone is mean to that one girl for the

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whole day.

BRADIE: ***Why?*** Adrienne doesn't know. It's just a part of school. At first penalty day is hard to figure out. There are a lot of rules. The person we have to be mean to has fleas of course. Everyone has to write FP for flea proof on their hand.

By the end of grade four penalty day had become as complex as World War Two. But who the enemy was had become entirely simple. I don't know why it was Sofie. It just was.

ADRIENNE: **[Pg 34-35]** No one is to have contact of any kind with IT from first period until lunch. If you have to address IT do so during homeroom. On the school bus IT has to sit on the fourth seat on the left. If IT talks to any boys, IT will be dealt with by me. Case closed. IT will make no comments and will not be allowed to look at me anymore as of now.

SOFIE: Don't call me that

ADRIENNE: *(mimicking)* Don't call me that.

AMBER: What if she . .

ADRIENNE: IT

AMBER: What if IT has to go to the bathroom?

BRADIE: Adrienne ignores her and turns her back on Sofie, to show us she means business. Adrienne always means business.

[By middle school] There is a brand-new code every day. **[Pg 41]** Sofie is accused of watching the girls get undressed in gym. **[Pg 35-36]** Adrienne is lifting up her tee-shirt. She is wearing a white bra covered in tiny pink flowers. Mine is identical. Adrienne watches Sofie. Sofie yanks up her blouse. She is wearing a rolled up undershirt.

ADRIENNE: God, look at IT!

SOFIE: It's a sports bra.

ADRIENNE: IT thinks that's a bra.

BRADIE: Sofie doesn't have a clue. She has no sense of how to avoid anything.

ADRIENNE: A sports bra is a defense against guys. The really high-end sports bras repel guys, totally impenetrable. A good sports bra will catapult guys across the room. THAT is NOT a sports bra. It's a little Miss Undie shirt. Gross.

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SOFIE: Ha ha.

BRADIE: Another one of Sofie's bad habits, haha-ing all the time. And all of a sudden everyone is laughing and Sofie is allowed to be our friend again. **[Pg 37-38]** So you probably didn't notice how still she was, with her eyes straight ahead. The girls across from her were chanting but you'd have to listen hard to hear it. **[Pg 39]** Girls are getting meaner.

[By the time we are in high school] **[Pg 34]** Part of me gets it. And I hate it that I do. But right now, if you put me in a room filled with girls, girls my age that I've never seen before in my life -- I could divide them all up. I could decide who goes where and just where I fit in.

[Pg 52] I have no idea why I feel I have to keep tabs on Sofie. I just do. She's a regular girl. But this girl, this regular girl, **[Pg 50]** she doesn't know, doesn't get the plot, doesn't understand her part. So it starts.

[Pg 52-56] Sometimes I follow her around. She has no idea; she has always been a fairly clued out individual. I go to the bus shelter after she's left to check it out. There are little rocks lined up along the sides and she's carved her initials S.G. into the seat. No doubt it all is charged with meaning in the world of Sofie. I watch Sofie board the bus, always first on so that she can sit directly behind the driver.

[Then] just when you think it was all ancient history it starts again -- three weeks ago, in the girls bathroom. Right after home room. I walk in. I'm not doing anything, I'm minding my own business, I just have to pee. Sofie is there. Applying this goofy blue eyeliner in a goofy blue line. Then guess-who comes kicking her way out of the end cubicle. Adrienne's been crying; her eyes are rabbity pink. No doubt there has been some new atrocity between her and [her boyfriend] Justin. *Let's* go. That's me, trying to head her off but Adrienne has already seen Sofie. ***A girl in the shape of a monster A monster in the shape of a girl.***

ADRIENNE: What are you looking at?

BRADIE: Sofie goes blank. She turns and fixes her sights on the tampon machine.

ADRIENNE: I asked you a question.

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BRADIE: But Sofie is still in statue mode, uninhabited. No doubt Sofie's entire school life is an out of body experience. Adrienne drops her Atlas on Sofie's foot. Sofie doesn't blink.

ADRIENNE: Pick it up. I said pick it up.

BRADIE: Do something, say something, anything, fight. Do something, say something, anything, fight. . . But Sofie just bends over. And I hate her. As soon as she does it, I know she's lost. Adrienne kicks Sofie down on all fours. All the work she'd put into being invisible, down the drain.

ADRIENNE: Lovely. Sofie the horse.

BRADIE: Sofie tries to get up and Adrienne's boot comes down in the center of Sofie's back.

ADRIENNE: Did I say you could get up?

BRADIE: Sofie tries to turn her head around but Adrienne grabs her by the shirt.

ADRIENNE: Maybe the horse needs a drink of water.

BRADIE: Adrienne pulls Sofie over to the toilet. And yes, finally. Sofie's head is turning, twisting away from Adrienne and . . . turning toward me.

SOFIE: Braidie, please.

BRADIE: You do what you have to do. You look down. Like this. And then you navigate your way to the door using only your peripheral vision.

After school, when I get on the bus, Adrienne is waiting for me. *(to Adrienne)* Adrienne. What happened? *(to audience)* But she does't know what I'm talking about, can't remember, just a regular day. *(to Adrienne)* What happened to Sofie?

ADRIENNE: Nothing happened.

BRADIE: I see the empty seat behind the driver on the bus, Sofie's seat. A tremor starts; my hands are shaking. And Adrienne is gone; the friend I loved is gone. All that's left is the shape of a girl. ***A girl in the shape of a monster A monster in the shape of a girl.***

The driver lets me off. I walk back to school. I go right into the girls' bathroom. I hear a sound from the last cubicle. Sofie is sitting on the lid of the toilet. Her lips all puffed up and purple. When she sees who it is, she covers her head. . . She's acting like I'm going to hit her, which is so crazy. *I never did anything.*

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[Pg 50] The ones who watched. Maybe they were so glad to not be that girl that they don't even know how to imagine shouting stop. Maybe they think silence is the ticket, the only way to never end up like the girl [who] looked up and begged for help.

[Pg 56] Sofie rocks back and forth then all of a sudden, she smashes her head into the side of the stall.

We did a good job. Even Sofie hates Sofie.

[Pg 58] And I understand for the first time what I have to say: ***I wish to report the behavior of . . . I'm scared. Scared for the safety of another girl. That she might do something crazy. Her name is Sofie. She has been treated in a despicable way by many people . . . including me.***

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2022 National Qualifier – MS
CA State Qualifier

****Introductory Quotation and additional material about bullying***
https://patch.com/us/across-america/girl-girl-bullying-why-it-s-different-difficult-confront

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